

Japanese Landscape Architecture: Artificially Controlling Natural Chaos

A 1991 study done by Stephen Kellert contrasts attitudes towards nature between Japan and the United States. His article discusses the tendency to label Japanese people as exceptionally interested in nature. However, Japan's population was found to share rather similar sentiments with the United States' in all categories except for one: "Dominionistic". This category measured the respondents' desires to control nature, to which Japanese interviewees indicated interest in at nearly double the rate of American interviewees (301). Though the significant extent of this cultural difference may be surprising, Japan's penchant for creating and controlling nature can be seen throughout its history, across its arts, and within its traditions. One such area of Japanese culture, landscape architecture, readily demonstrates the love of distilling the environment into its fundamental impressions. Japanese landscape architecture, from tradition through modern day, has kept its premier design philosophy of simplifying the chaos of nature using control.

A traditional definition of a landscape architect would be "a person whose job is to plan and create large outdoor spaces such as gardens, parks, etc." ("Landscape Architect"). However, for the purpose of this paper, what I refer to as landscape architecture will simply be any human construct that shares themes of nature, ecology, and spatial relationships. The ecological traits may be realized in abstract ways, especially in the cases of the traditional art forms discussed in this paper. For example, *suiseki* works, as described below, do not contain a true ecological component, but they do share an organic discussion with their environments. Likewise, "Ueno Planet", Haruka Misawa's body of graphic illustrations (also discussed below), does not innately contain an ecological component, yet it does contain themes of ecology and the relationships of nature and space. In this manner, all of the designers, works, and forms discussed below can be considered varieties of landscape architecture, even if they are not all constructed "outdoor environments" ("Landscape Architecture").



Fig. 1. An example of *suiseki* (Ensō).

Suiseki and *bonsai* are both art forms that are rooted in Japanese tradition and are still being practiced today. *Suiseki*, originating in the seventh century, involves the mounting of a natural rock onto a wooden base (see fig. 1) (Coussins 244). *Suiseki* are known to be appreciated for the intricacies carved by millennia's worth of natural forces acting on the stone. The base acts as a pedestal for the stone, representing the admiration and glorification of nature. However, this is only in a decidedly artificial setting. Thus, I imagine that it is neither the rock nor the base themselves – each mundane on their own — that are truly valued. Instead it is the juxtaposition of nature with the domain of man that creates the work of art. The rock is no longer simply a rock, it becomes a symbol of nature, or, more precisely, a symbol of control over nature. *Suiseki* embodies the human ability to transform natural spaces into complex architectural structures, and then to reintroduce such symbols of nature at will.



Fig. 2. An example of *bonsai* (“The Slanting Style in Bonsai”).

By the ninth century, the concept of growing trees in containers, creating miniature versions of their natural counterparts (see fig. 2), was adopted from China and integrated into Japanese culture (“History of Bonsai”). Known as *bonsai*, these works involve removing natural elements from their original context, much like in the case of *suiseki*. Unlike *suiseki*, however, *bonsai* are not simply admired in their new artificial contexts. In order to be considered artworks, the *bonsai* must then be trimmed and grown using such tools as wire frames and shears to create structured growth. As *Utsubo Monogatari*, Japan’s oldest full-length narrative, states, “A tree that is left growing in its natural state is a crude thing. It is only when it is kept close to human beings who fashion it with loving care that its shape and style acquire the ability to move one.” (Ewart). This quote shows that even from *bonsai*’s earliest incarnations, it is more than the introduction of nature into the human domain that induces admiration; the heavy human manipulation involved also contributes to its overall perceived beauty.



Fig. 3. An example of *karesansui* (“枯山水 *Karesansui*”)

Karesansui is the most traditional form of landscape architecture in Japan, practiced consistently for centuries and still commonplace today. Also known as Japanese rock gardens, *karesansui* involves the disciplined arrangement of various natural components into a work of art that captures the essence of nature (see fig. 3) (Nitschke 65). Though abstracted, *karesansui* follow very specific formulas. These formulas use angles and design principles to dictate the placement of rocks in respect to each other and in regard to the primary viewpoint (“Japanese Garden of Stones”). While these formulas are extremely complex and precise, they develop the creation of an aesthetically minimalist arrangement that allows the viewer to feel pleased and at peace. The stones used are, of course, as with *suiseki*, collected from nature. However, the source of the stones, nature itself (which by definition contains the essence of nature), is not admired without alteration. The stones must be removed from nature and repositioned in a human context, dictated by manmade principles of design rather than by the coincidence and chaos of nature, in order to be truly deemed pleasing.



Fig. 4. An example of Amano's work (Amano).

Many modern and postmodern designers, such as Takashi Amano and Mirei Shigemori, base their practices in the blending of such traditional aesthetics and philosophies with contemporary methods and ideas. Takashi Amano was a Japanese aquarium designer who, in the 1990s, advocated a revolutionary style of aquascaping (the art of aquatic gardening). Amano's style of aquascaping, known as the Nature Aquarium (see fig. 4), is based in his philosophy of creating actively maintained tanks that appear as though they are maintained by the hand of nature ("Nature Aquarium"). The Nature Aquarium movement's western counterpart, the Jungle Style movement, advocates for only as much maintenance as necessary and strives to create a truly chaotic natural aesthetic ("The Jungle Style Aquarium"). While both aquascaping styles have similar goals of representing nature, this holds different meanings in each. I credit this to the cultural differences in the human relationship with nature that are outlined by Kellert's aforementioned study. The Nature Aquarium, though it too seeks to embody nature, uses much more human intervention than the Jungle Style. The plants are carefully placed, and their growth patterns are meticulously restricted and manipulated in order to achieve the desired "natural" look. The Jungle Style contrastingly offers the same (or even greater) level of natural appeal but lacks the aspect of control that

defines Amano's style. Thus, it is shown that Amano's audience is more interested in the control component of his work rather than the nature component.



Fig. 5. An example of Shigemori's work (Wada).

Mirei Shigemori, another revolutionary designer, is the most influential landscape architect in modern Japanese history. In *Rebel in the Garden*, a book on Shigemori's philosophies and works, author Christian Tschumi states that "the main leitmotif running through [Shigemori's] work" was "an obsession to 'modernize' the garden art of Japan." (13). Shigemori accomplished this through the use of innovative materials in innovative ways, but his designs remained rooted in Japanese tradition (see fig. 5). During his lifetime, he surveyed hundreds of Japanese *karesansui* works alongside studying contemporary Western art movements (35). This enabled him to draw inspiration from a variety of aesthetic philosophies and apply it to his creations. His art set precedence for casting aside the precise formulas of true *karesansui*, favoring instead an open-minded approach, as well as for using synthetic materials, such as cement, that are no longer taken directly from nature (14). While he was thus able to significantly diverge from traditional *karesansui* gardens, breaking the boundaries of the discipline, his works do not depart from

the use of control to fabricate an idealistically simple form of nature. Formulaic or not, his works still shun natural chaos, and organic or not, his materials are still used in a way that evokes nature's aura.



Fig. 6. Ando's Benesse House Oval (Rogers).

Another renowned Japanese architect, Tadao Ando, is acclaimed for his structures that masterfully incorporate water features and blend indoor and outdoor spaces (Rogers). I contend that he is truly recognized, however, for his creation of spaces that allow for the appreciation of nature through controlled simplification. For example, Ando's Benesse House Oval is characterized solely by the skylight that dominates the ceiling and the pool that dominates the floor (see fig. 6). With its gray concrete structure, no other interior elements are drawn attention to. The viewer has only the sky and its reflection in the pool to admire. Thus, the sky becomes a picture, framed in gray, and the pool, a painting if you will – with subtle ripples stylizing what would otherwise be a duplicate of the view above. By providing a defined border around the environment, Ando is able to simplify nature for the viewer, effectively deconstructing three dimensions into two. What is gained alongside this loss of dimension is a more accessible appreciation of nature, more in line with the form of nature most urbanized people are

accustomed to – a framed scenic photograph sitting on an office desk or perhaps a landscape painting hanging in a museum.



Fig. 7. Ando's Water Temple (Conley).

The Water Temple, another of Ando's buildings, carries with it a similar appeal (see fig. 7). Its exterior is dominated by a large lily pond. However, what sets Ando's pond apart from other ponds is its refined appearance. The pond is framed by a perfect circle of concrete and the lilies are planted in an even grid submerged under an unnaturally uniform depth of water. Despite these measures, the pond's natural beauty is enhanced, not subdued. The waterlilies are drawn attention to by the lack of other focal points. The circular border of the pond, devoid of cattails and other natural interruptions, also holds nothing that may capture the viewer's eye. The soft radial symmetry instead guides the viewer back to the lilies. Once again, the natural lilies floating on the water are what the viewer ultimately cherishes, but their appreciation is only demanded by the controlled environment in which they are placed, not by their intrinsic organic qualities.



Fig. 8. An artwork in Misawa's "Waterscape" body of work (Panagiotopoulou).

Haruka Misawa is a less-known contemporary Japanese designer; however, her work is also worth noting, especially as it reflects a trend in Japanese design. Alongside such designers as Aki Inomata (Inomata) and Kohei Nawa (Nawa), Haruka Misawa uses new technology to create works that blur the line between natural and artificial. In her body of work "Waterscape", Misawa incorporates 3D-printed sculptures into fish tanks (see fig. 8) ("Works"). Despite the precise mathematical structures and technology-heavy process, she is still able to maintain an organic sense of nature in her works. The use of technology creates a sense of precision and perfection that is impossible to achieve in nature, but it does not detract from the works' original natural inspirations. Her works do not attempt to escape nature, but instead to reimagine and re-contextualize it.

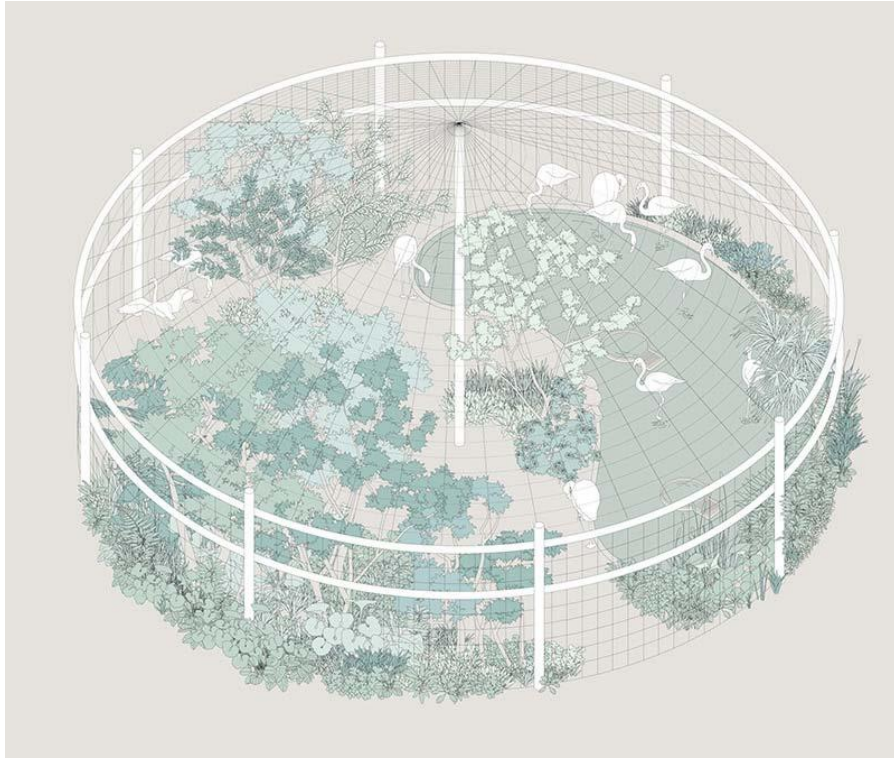


Fig. 9. An artwork in Misawa's "Ueno Planet" body of work (Fabrizi).

Another body of work by Misawa, "Ueno Planet", approaches Tokyo's zoo from a new perspective (see fig. 9). In 2009, Ueno Zoo attracted more than three million visitors, making it Japan's most-visited zoo (Nbakki). Thus, many Japanese residents feel a personal familiarity with the zoo, which Misawa aims to deconstruct in her graphic renderings of the park, hoping to offer a new experience in its place. She cites her decision to use the "viewpoint of a bird flying" as the principle tool to achieve this objective ("Works"), but I argue that Misawa is successful in this goal because she approaches the objective from a similar angle as the designers with which she shares her national identity. She takes the natural aspects of the zoo – its land, flora, and fauna – and desaturates them, limiting the colors to a dichromatic palette. In doing so, she restricts the visual input the viewer receives from her illustrations, creating a pleasingly minimalist version of nature instead.

The examples I discussed reveal a uniquely consistent philosophy of control in Japanese landscape design. However, they also demonstrate the progression and revision of this philosophy, more so in its application than in its ideology. As new technology is available, new technology is dogmatically applied by designers. Though masters of the ancient forms still practice traditional methods, artists such as Mirei Shigemori (those who attempt to break free from the original rubrics for Japanese arts) are the ones that become regarded as influential drivers of change. Alongside rapid modernization and innovation, not only in Japan but also globally, this is the expected step in the design world. Even with this new technology though, modern Japanese artists manage to maintain the close connection with nature in their works. The timelessness of how Japanese designers incorporate nature can thus be paradoxically attributed to this dependence on technology. Even from the development of *suiseki* works, which held value proportional to the complexity of the built environments in which they were placed, all the way through Misawa's works, which rely on computer graphics and 3D printing, technology has been a fundamental component in encouraging the Japanese public to appreciate nature. If it were to lack technology contemporary to the artworks' creation, Japanese design would offer little that pure, unadulterated nature does not. So, Japanese design, in the façade of demonstrating how in sync humanity is with nature, proves just the opposite. It flexes human ingenuity, boasts how far we have come from our natural origins, and demonstrates the lengths we go to recreate nature in our lives.

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